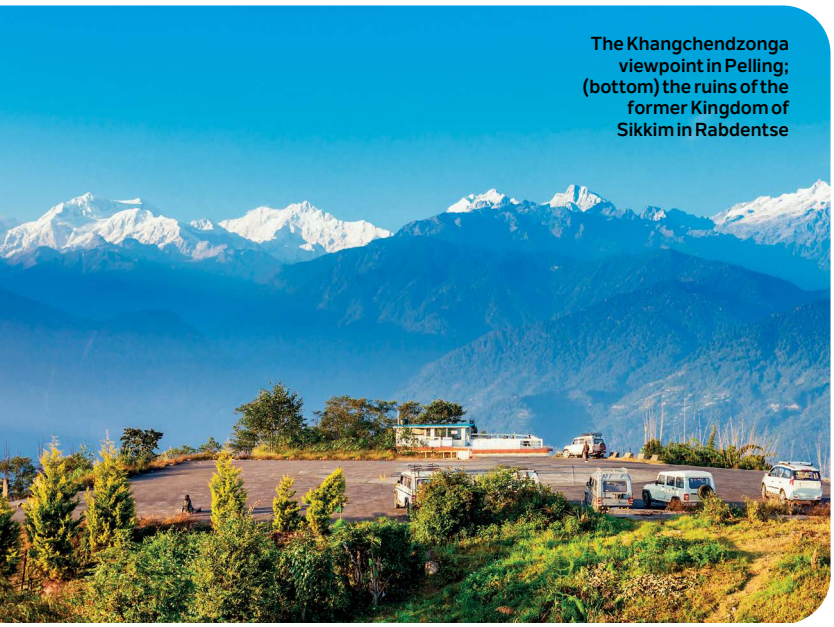
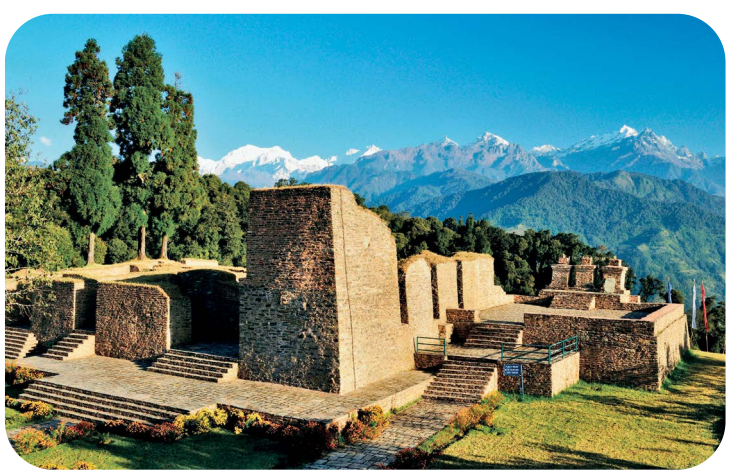


The Khangchendzonga viewpoint in Pelling; (bottom) the ruins of the former Kingdom of Sikkim in Rabdentse

Pelling

Popular with trekkers since it's where many great climbing trails start, this town in western Sikkim has a fascinating history as well. You can see the ruins of Rabdentse, the second capital of the former Kingdom of Sikkim in the times of the Chogyal dynasty. Dating back to as far back as 1670 AD, the kingdom was destroyed by Gurkha invaders. Walking around the complex to take in what remains of three stone chortens, the king's throne, and royal palace, you hear the wind whisper *song khim* (new palace) as this new capital was dubbed, eventually inspiring the name Sikkim. Not far away is the early 18th century Pemayangtse Monastery with some of the most precious art on its walls, including the most magnificent mural called 'Heavenly Palace' on the top level. While Sikkim is rich in waterfalls, the Khangchendzonga and Changey falls near Pelling are quite splendid. The holy Khecheopalri Lake is both spiritual as well as scenic, making it a popular stop for worshippers and tourists alike.



ALAMY

Yuksom

It's often called the gateway to the majestic Mount Khangchendzonga. Since 2016, the Khangchendzonga National Park was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Trekking to the park, visiting the ancient monasteries and the mystical Kartok Lake will transport you to a different world.



ALAMY

Prayer flags on the banks of the Kartok Lake

You may well be a believer or opine that religion is the opiate of the masses. But either way, the soulfulness you experience while travelling through Sikkim is different. It's an awe that is inspired by the state's natural abundance, its alluring sights, and the warmth. ■